
PDF design system

The visual system for PDF documents produced from a project (proposals, reports, internal plans, briefs). The goal is a single, recognisable look across everything we hand to clients or share internally, anchored to a refined editorial typography stack.

The canonical stylesheet is `docs/pdf-style.css` . Every PDF generated through this system is built from a markdown source plus that stylesheet. Do not fork the CSS per document; extend the system if a real new need shows up.

How to produce a PDF

```
pandoc docs/<source>.md -o /tmp/out.html \  
  --standalone \  
  --metadata pagetitle="Document title for HTML head" \  
  --css=docs/pdf-style.css \  
  --embed-resources \  
  -V lang=en  
  
weasyprint /tmp/out.html docs/<source>.pdf
```

Use `--metadata pagetitle=...` (sets only the HTML `<title>`). Do not use `--metadata title=...` - it injects a duplicate H1 into the body on top of the markdown H1.

Web fonts are fetched at render time from Google Fonts (`@import` in the CSS). The container needs network access during render. Fonts are then embedded into the resulting PDF, so the file is portable.

Brand foundation

Colors

The default palette is anchored to a navy/gold/cream brand. Override the CSS custom properties in `:root` if your project uses a different palette - the rest of the system inherits from these tokens.

TOKEN	DEFAULT	USE
Navy	#1A3D6D	H1, H2, H3 (when nested), links, page numbers, table header text
Navy deep	#122a4e	inline code text
Gold	#C9A575	rules above headings, link underlines, code-block left border, hr
Gold deep	#a8854f	list bullets, ordered numerals
Cream	#F9F3E9	inline code background
Cream warm	#fbf8f1	code-block background
Ink	#181818	strong/bold text
Text	#2d2d2d	default body text
Muted	#707070	running header, wordmark, lead paragraph
Line	#d8d2c4	section divider above H2
Line soft	#ece6d6	table row dividers

Typography

Three families, all variable, all loaded from Google Fonts.

- **Fraunces** (display serif) - distinctive humanist, optical sizes 9-144. Used for H1, H2, H3, table headers, page numbers. The optical-size axis means H1 at 30pt looks sculpted while H3 at 12pt still reads as the same family.
- **Source Serif 4** (text serif) - designed for both screen and print, optical sizes 8-60. Used for body, italic lead paragraphs, H4, table cells.
- **JetBrains Mono** (monospace) - clean and even-weighted. Used for inline code, code blocks, and ASCII diagrams. Ligatures off (so ASCII art renders correctly).

Type scale

ELEMENT	FAMILY	SIZE	WEIGHT	COLOR	NOTES
H1	Fraunces	30 pt	600	Navy	Title only. Gold rule above (2.5em x 2pt). Tight tracking -0.022em
H1 lead paragraph	Source Serif 4 italic	12.5 pt	400	#4a4a4a	First paragraph after H1. Treated as document subtitle
H2	Fraunces	16.5 pt	600	Navy	Top-level section. Thin gold marker over a 0.5pt line on top
H3	Fraunces	12 pt	600	Ink	Subsection under H2. No decoration
H4	Source Serif 4	10.5 pt	600	Navy	Rare. Use for paragraph-level labels in long sections
Body	Source Serif 4	10.5 pt	400	Text	Line-height 1.58. Hyphenation on
Strong	Source Serif 4	10.5 pt	600	Ink	For emphasized words, lead-in labels

ELEMENT	FAMILY	SIZE	WEIGHT	COLOR	NOTES
Inline code	JetBrains Mono	0.86 em	400	Navy deep	Cream back-ground, 2px radius
Code block	JetBrains Mono	7.6 pt	400	Ink	Cream-warm back-ground, 2pt gold left border, line-height 1.35
Table header	Fraunces uppercase	8.8 pt	600	Navy	Letter-spacing 0.07em. 1.5pt navy bottom border
Table cell	Source Serif 4	9.8 pt	400	Text	0.5pt line-soft row dividers. Tabular figures from column 2
Page number	Fraunces	10 pt	600	Navy	Bottom right of every page after first
Wordmark	Fraunces	8 pt	500	Muted	Uppercase, letter-spacing 0.18em, bottom left. Empty by default; project-specific (see below)
Running header	Source Serif 4 italic	8.5 pt	400	Muted	Document title from H1. Top left

Hierarchy rules

- One H1 per document. It is the title and runs into the running header automatically (`string-set: doctitle`).
 - H2 for top-level sections. Always preceded by a section break (visual: thin gold marker + line).
 - H3 for subsections under H2. Don't use H3 outside an H2.
 - Don't skip levels (no H1 to H3 jump).
 - For short labelled paragraphs use a bold lead-in: `**Label.** Body sentence...` . Don't promote those to H4 unless the section is long enough to need a real subheading.
 - Sentence case for headings, never title case (“Why we build it on this stack”, not “Why We Build It On This Stack”).
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Page setup

- **Format:** A4 (210 x 297 mm)
- **Margins:** 2.4 cm top, 2 cm sides, 2.6 cm bottom
- **First page:** 3.8 cm top margin, no running header, no wordmark, no page number. The title carries the page on its own.
- **Subsequent pages:**
 - Top left: running header (italic title from H1)
 - Bottom left: project wordmark (empty by default - see “Project wordmark” below)
 - Bottom right: page number

The first-page rule keeps title pages clean. Hand-off feel.

Project wordmark

The bottom-left of every page after the first is reserved for a project wordmark - usually a brand name in small caps. The styling (font, size, letter-spacing, color) is fixed by the design system. The text content is per-project.

Default: empty. The bottom-left margin box is rendered with no visible text.

To set a wordmark for a specific project, override the `--wordmark` custom property. The simplest way is a small project-specific CSS file that imports the canonical stylesheet:

```
@import url('pdf-style.css');

:root {
  --wordmark: "Acme Co";
}
```

Then render with `--css=pdf-style-acme.css` instead of `--css=pdf-style.css`. Everything else (palette, type scale, page chrome) stays the same.

This is also the right place to override brand colors per project. Drop the override CSS in `docs/` next to the canonical stylesheet.

Components

Headings

H1 - tight, large, navy. Gold rule above (2.5em x 2pt) acts as a small typographic mark, not a divider. The H1 sets the running header for the rest of the document via `string-set`.

H2 - the visual cue is a thin gold marker (1.4em x 1.6pt) that sits on top of a full-column 0.5pt line. The marker reads as a sectioning device; the line gives the section breathing room from the previous content. Padding-top + margin-top combine to produce that breath without forcing a page break.

H3 - no decoration. Family-and-color hierarchy alone signals depth.

Lists

- Unordered lists use an em-dash — marker in gold deep (not the default disc bullet). Hanging indent so wrapped lines align under the body, not under the marker.
- Ordered lists use gold-deep Fraunces numerals (size 10pt, weight 700) at the right of the left column. The numeral alignment makes 1-9 line up neatly with 10+ even on the same list.
- Nested lists: same conventions one level deeper. Avoid going past two levels of nesting.

Tables

Use tables when comparing items across attributes. They beat parallel bullet lists for clarity.

- Header: Fraunces uppercase, navy color, 1.5pt navy bottom border. Reads like a small caption.
- Cells: 0.55em vertical padding. 0.5pt line-soft horizontal dividers between rows.
- Last row gets a 1pt navy border (closes the table).
- Numeric columns get tabular figures automatically (column 2 onward).

Code blocks

Used for ASCII diagrams, file trees, and any code samples.

- Background: cream-warm `#fbf8f1` (just enough off-white to set apart from the page)
- Left border: 2pt gold (the same accent that marks H1 and H2)
- Font: JetBrains Mono 7.6pt, line-height 1.35, ligatures off
- `page-break-inside: avoid` - code blocks stay together on one page. If a diagram is taller than a page, simplify or split it; do not let it span pages

ASCII diagrams: left-align without leading whitespace. The gold border + cream background already separates them visually; centring with leading spaces wastes width and breaks at narrow column widths.

Inline code

- Cream background `#F9F3E9`
- JetBrains Mono 0.86em
- 2px border-radius, light padding
- Use for: file paths, function names, env vars, short literal values

Links

Navy with a gold underline (0.5pt, 2px offset). Underline indicates link without using a different color, which would clash with the navy heading hierarchy.

Horizontal rule

A short gold line (3em wide, centred, 1px). Use sparingly - it's a "section divider within a section" device, not a section break (H2 already does that).

Writing conventions for PDF docs

- Title is one short H1 phrase. No subtitle inside the H1 - use the lead paragraph for a one-sentence subtitle.
- Sentence case headings, always.
- Hyphens for ranges and dashes (`5-7 weeks` , not `5–7 weeks`). No em-dashes.
- Straight quotes only.
- Three plain dots if you must use ellipsis. Better: rewrite to avoid it.
- No emoji, no Unicode bullets, no non-breaking spaces.

- ASCII diagrams: narrow enough that 7.6pt Mono fits the column without horizontal overflow. Test by rendering before committing.
- Tables over deep nested bullet lists for comparison content.
- Bold lead-ins for short labelled paragraphs (**Label** Body ...). Don't bold full sentences.

File conventions

FILE	ROLE
<code>docs/pdf-style.css</code>	Canonical stylesheet. Single source of truth for visual style
<code>docs/pdf-style-<project>.css</code>	Optional project override. Imports the canonical CSS, sets <code>--wordmark</code> and any color overrides
<code>docs/<doc-name>.md</code>	Markdown source (the editable artifact)
<code>docs/<doc-name>.pdf</code>	Generated output. Regenerate from markdown; never edit directly

PDFs are committed to the repo so they're shareable from a single link, but the markdown is the source of truth. If the PDF and markdown disagree, regenerate.

Updating the design system

- Palette or typography changes happen in `pdf-style.css` and propagate to every PDF on next render.
- Re-render an existing PDF and compare side by side before merging.
- One-off documents do not get one-off CSS overrides. If a real new need appears, add a class to `pdf-style.css` and document it here.

Toolchain

- pandoc 3.x for markdown to HTML

- WeasyPrint 68+ for HTML to PDF
- Google Fonts (Fraunces, Source Serif 4, JetBrains Mono) fetched via `@import` and embedded in the PDF